

11.1 Tools of the Trade

As a customer of online entertainment, nothing is more important than having a broadband connection. Without this you will be unable to truly appreciate this form of entertainment—there will be significant delays in streamed data, and downloading will take time.

Then come media players that can play the popular media formats used for online media distribution. To enjoy streaming media, the relevant applications are Windows Media Player, Real Player, Quick Time Player/iTunes, and Winamp. More recently, the Flash Video (FLV) format has become a popular medium for streaming data, and for this you only need a browser with the Flash plugin. Downloaded FLV content can be played on a suitable FLV player, such as FLV Player and Riva FLV Encoder.

Downloadable content uses codecs to compress and thus get smaller, so you would need to install codecs to be able to watch it. Codecs not supported by the above-mentioned media players and are popular are DivX and XVID. The necessary codecs can be downloaded individually, or an all-in-one codec pack like K-Lite can be installed.

Browser-wise, it is best to use either IE or Firefox, and since file sizes can be massive, it is recommended to use a download manager. Depending on the integration between the different media players and browsers, the experience for the streaming content audience can vary. Usually links open the corresponding player and start streaming content, but sometimes, one finds that just a small file gets downloaded. The downloaded file contains the URL to the content. In such cases, if the corresponding media player is installed, double-clicking on the file should start the stream; if it doesn't, manually launch the media player and use **File > Open** to start streaming the just-downloaded file.

Some content is distributed using the BitTorrent protocol, in which case a BitTorrent client such as utorrent (utorrent.com) will be needed to download it.